NewsBank inc.

California Leads the Way in School Food Safety with Ban on Artificial Dyes

October 4, 2024 | One Green Planet (USA)
Section: News | 561 Words
OpenURL Link

California has taken a major step in promoting healthier school meals by becoming the first state to ban six artificial food dyes linked to potential health and behavioral issues. Governor Gavin Newsom recently signed Assembly Bill 2316, also known as the California School Food Safety Act, into law. This legislation specifically targets dyes like Red 40, Yellow 5, Yellow 6, Blue 1, Blue 2, and Green 3, which are commonly found in snacks, drinks, and meals served in public schools.

Introduced by Democratic Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel in March, this law follows years of research indicating that synthetic dyes may be harmful, particularly to children. In 2021, a review by the California Environmental Protection Agency's Office of Environmental Health Hazard Assessment found that food dyes can trigger hyperactivity, inattentiveness, and restlessness in some children. These adverse effects were observed in both children diagnosed with behavioral conditions like ADHD and those without such diagnoses. "The evidence supports a relationship between food dye exposure and adverse behavioral outcomes in children, both with and without pre-existing behavioral disorders," researchers concluded.

Gabriel expressed his enthusiasm after the bill's approval, stating, "We're feeling really proud of the fact that we are changing the national conversation around food safety. It is very clear that these are chemicals that can harm kids and interfere with their ability to learn."

The new law, set to take effect on December 31, 2027, does not ban any specific foods outright. Instead, it requires food manufacturers to replace the artificial dyes in their products with natural alternatives, like beet or carrot juice. Many companies already follow this practice in other parts of the world, such as the European Union, where synthetic dyes are prohibited.

This transition period gives manufacturers ample time to reformulate their products. Gabriel is hopeful that this move will inspire more significant change nationwide, particularly as ADHD diagnoses continue to rise, according to the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention.

For years, consumer advocacy groups have pushed for tighter regulations on artificial dyes. They argue that the FDA's approval of these additives is based on outdated research, and more recent studies suggest that children are especially vulnerable to the potential harmful effects of synthetic chemicals. "What made this type of law necessary is that FDA hasn't been able or willing to do anything about these issues for several decades," said Brian Ronholm, director of food policy at Consumer Reports.

In response to the growing concern, the FDA recently held a public meeting to discuss food chemicals, including artificial color additives, and has begun soliciting public comments as it reviews its food safety policies. The agency emphasized that food safety remains a top priority and is working on a more comprehensive approach to reassessing chemicals used in food.

However, some industry groups, like the International Food Additives Council, have criticized state-specific laws like California's, arguing that they could complicate national food regulations. The council warned that such legislation might increase costs and create confusion for consumers. "This approach fosters unnecessary fear and mistrust in the federal system," the group stated.

With California leading the charge, there is hope that these state-level initiatives will encourage more significant federal action. Gabriel is optimistic that the California School Food Safety Act will set a precedent, pushing for nationwide reforms that ensure children are eating safer, healthier meals.

Copyright @ One Green Planet LLC. All rights reserved. Provided by SyndiGate Media Inc. (Syndigate.info).

© Copyright 2024 One Green Planet. All rights reserved.

- **Citation (apa Style)**
  California Leads the Way in School Food Safety with Ban on Artificial Dyes. (2024, October 4).*One Green Planet (USA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/19C0C4DF9A7DE7F8.